



Say Earth Orbit First: A Letter to NASA

Student copy (project or hand out)

In the following open letter, written after NASA announced the crew of the Artemis III mission on June 9, 2026, a planetarium educator who hosts school field trips asks the agency to change how the flight is described to young audiences.

1 To the National Aeronautics and Space Administration: I write from a low seat. I run the dome theater at a city planetarium, where my equipment amounts to a star projector, a microphone, and a carpet that has outlasted four directors; you, for your part, fly people off the planet. On June 9 you announced the four astronauts of Artemis III: commander Randy Bresnik, pilot Luca Parmitano, and mission specialists Frank Rubio and Andre Douglas. I have been saying their names out loud in the empty dome all week, practicing.

2 You will expect a letter like this one to want something, because letters like this one always want something: a poster, or a school visit, or a signed photograph for the lobby case. I am not asking for any of that. I am writing because of a girl in the second row on Tuesday, a few hours after your announcement, maybe nine years old, who held her hand up through the entire show and then asked me whether the four people on the screen would walk on the Moon. I told her the truth, and the truth took three sentences longer than she wanted. Artemis III is not the landing.

3 Let me grant you something first, freely: wonder is your trade, you have been good at it for longer than I have been alive, and the crew you chose needs no varnish from me or from anyone. You named a commander who has flown twice and commanded the International Space Station during Expedition 53; you named a pilot, Luca Parmitano, the station's first Italian commander and the first European Space Agency astronaut assigned to an Artemis mission; you named Frank Rubio, a board-certified physician and flight surgeon who left on a Soyuz in September 2022 and did not come home for 371 days, the longest single spaceflight any American has flown; and you named Andre Douglas, a backup for Artemis II who has never been to space. Children gasp at the 371. Nobody has to tell them to.

4 And yet the flight plan, stated plainly, is this: Artemis III is targeted to launch in 2027 and will test rendezvous and docking, in Earth orbit, with test articles, practice versions, of the Blue Origin and SpaceX lunar landers; the first crewed landing at the Moon's South Pole is planned for Artemis IV, as early as 2028. If you trusted the plain record when you picked these four, if a doctor who was gone for 371 days and a pilot on loan from another continent's space agency were inspiring enough without any dressing, then the itinerary deserves the same confidence: lead with Earth orbit. Put it in the first sentence, not the fine print. The girl in the second row can hold two true things at once. She proved it before her bus left.

5 My fall calendar starts filling in late September, school groups mostly, four buses on a good Friday. Before the first of them arrives, publish one description of this mission that a nine-year-old could read to

the end of its second sentence and still know where the spacecraft is going, and where it is not yet going. You hold the larger instrument here; I only hold the microphone. Whatever you write, I will read it aloud under the dome, in the dark, to children with their hands already up. That part is mine.

AP-style multiple choice:

1. In the third paragraph, the writer catalogues the crew's flights, records, and firsts primarily to
 - A) emphasize the physical dangers the astronauts will face during the 2027 flight
 - B) concede that the writer lacks the expertise to evaluate the crew's qualifications
 - C) establish that the mission's plain facts can move an audience without embellishment
 - D) question whether NASA has selected a crew experienced enough for a lunar landing
2. In the first and final paragraphs, the writer's references to his own equipment ("a star projector, a microphone," "I only hold the microphone") serve primarily to
 - A) lower the speaker's standing so the request rests on the addressee's power rather than the writer's authority
 - B) suggest that planetariums lack the resources to keep pace with modern spaceflight
 - C) illustrate the technical difficulty of presenting astronomy to school-age children
 - D) contrast the writer's honesty with the agency's deceptive publicity practices

Discussion questions:

1. The writer asks NASA to "lead with Earth orbit" even though the plainer description is less exciting than a Moon landing. When does simplifying a story for an audience cross into misleading it, and who should get to decide where that line sits?
2. The letter is addressed to NASA, but it is written to be read by everyone. How does knowing the public is overhearing change what the writer can say, and how does it change what the agency can afford to do in response?

Writing prompt (Q3 argument):

In an open letter to NASA, a planetarium educator claims that even a young audience "can hold two true things at once," and asks the agency to lead its public descriptions with the plain facts of a mission rather than its most exciting framing. Write an essay that argues your position on the extent to which institutions, such as agencies, schools, and companies, should favor plain accuracy over excitement when communicating with the public. In your response you should: respond to the prompt with a thesis that presents a defensible position; provide evidence to support your line of reasoning; explain how the evidence supports your line of reasoning; and use appropriate grammar and punctuation in communicating your argument.